

Microscopic life

It's easy to forget that many living things are too small for us to see. Some simple life forms are so tiny they have just one cell. Cells are the building blocks of our bodies – an adult human has around 60 trillion cells! The smallest organisms only show up under microscopes. Some powerful microscopes produce images in black and white, so colour is often added to make the pictures clearer. Microscopic life can include miniature animals and plants, and things that are neither, such as fungi. Follow this chapter from simple algae to tiny but complex animals.



Protozoans

These small organisms have a single cell that contains a nucleus, or “control centre”. They include tiny predators, such as amoebas, which flow like slime.



Archaea

These tiny life forms are very simple, yet tough. Like bacteria, they each consist of one cell, which does not have a nucleus, or “control centre”.